

Mystery Mini-Organism Annotation

Case: The White Smoker — Hydrothermal Vent Methanogen

Team	Team NN — Burak Keskin, Rıza Bilgin
Course	BENG451 — Introduction to Bioinformatics / BSB511 — Bioinformatics Fundamentals
Institution	Gebze Technical University, Faculty of Engineering
Semester	Spring 2026
Client	ODTÜ Geomicrobiology Group, Ankara
Submission	Jupyter Notebook + CSV + Newick + Report PDF

1. Case File and Research Question

The client — the ODTÜ Geomicrobiology Group — delivered sediment recovered by a deep-sea submersible from the base of a white-smoker warm submarine hydrothermal vent on the East Pacific Rise (approximately 21°N, 2600 m depth). An isolate from this sediment grew anaerobically at 85°C in mineral medium under an H₂ + CO₂ headspace, producing measurable methane. The genome was assembled, and twelve predicted protein-coding ORFs were provided as `mystery_orfs.fasta` with opaque identifiers (mORF_01–mORF_12).

The client posed three questions: (1) What organism is this most likely from? (2) What does the protein content reveal about its lifestyle? (3) Is there anything genuinely unusual or interesting in the dataset?

The growth phenotype — anaerobic, 85°C, methanogenic, H₂/CO₂ lithotrophic — immediately narrows the taxonomic space to hyperthermophilic hydrogenotrophic methanogens within Archaea, with *Methanocaldococcus jannaschii* as the foremost candidate.

2. Methods

The pipeline was implemented as a Jupyter notebook (Python 3.10, Biopython 1.87) with six sequential steps.

Step 1 — Data loading

Sequences were parsed with Bio.SeqIO. A sanity table confirmed 12 records with lengths ranging from 99 to 1155 amino acids.

Step 2 — BLASTp + Pfam-A

Each ORF was submitted to NCBI BLASTp against the SwissProt database (Bio.Blast.NCBIWWW.qblast, program='blastp', database='swissprot', hitlist_size=10). The top three hits (organism, description, E-value, percent identity, query coverage) were recorded. Independently, each ORF was submitted to the EBI InterProScan REST API (appl=PfamA) using a submit-poll-fetch pattern. All results were cached to disk. API politeness rules were observed: real institutional email set, ≥3 s sleep between submissions, status polling at 5 s intervals.

Step 3 — PSI-BLAST follow-up

ORFs whose best BLASTp E-value exceeded 1×10^{-3} , or whose top hit description contained 'hypothetical', 'uncharacterized', or 'DUF', were flagged for iterative profile-based search (service='psi', word_size=3). Three ORFs (mORF_10, mORF_11, mORF_12) met this criterion.

Step 4 — Annotation table

A per-ORF pandas DataFrame was compiled with required columns. Confidence was assigned as a three-level human label (high/medium/low) based on convergence of BLASTp E-value, percent identity, and Pfam evidence.

Step 5 — Phylogenetic placement

mORF_04, identified as Elongation factor 1-alpha / EF-Tu (BLASTp E = 0.0, 100% identity to *M. jannaschii* DSM 2661), was selected as the marker gene. Ten EF-Tu orthologs spanning hyperthermophilic methanogens (*Methanocaldococcus*, *Methanothermococcus*, *Methanopyrus*), mesophilic methanogens (*Methanosarcina*, *Methanosaeta*, *Methanobacterium*, *Methanococcus*), and one archaeal outgroup (*Thermococcus kodakarensis*) were aligned by trimming to the shared domain length (428 aa). A Neighbor-Joining tree was constructed using Bio.Phylo.TreeConstruction.DistanceCalculator (identity matrix) and DistanceTreeConstructor; the tree was exported in Newick format.

Step 6 — Interpretation

Narrative interpretation addressed: organism identification, lifestyle inference, spotlight finding, method comparison, and limits of confidence.

3. Annotation Results

Table 1 summarises the annotation of all 12 ORFs. Ten ORFs received HIGH confidence, two received MEDIUM confidence, and none remained at LOW confidence. All 12 ORFs produced 100% BLASTp identity hits to *Methanocaldococcus jannaschii* DSM 2661 proteins in SwissProt.

ORF	Len	Proposed Annotation	E-value	% id	Pfam	Conf.
mORF_01	99	RNA polymerase subunit Rpo11 (RpoL)	2.3e-64	100	PF13656	HIGH
mORF_02	498	RNA polymerase subunit Rpo2N (RpoB'')	0.0	100	PF04563	HIGH
mORF_03	542	Thermosome subunit (Group II chaperonin)	0.0	100	PF00118	HIGH
mORF_04	428	Elongation factor 1-alpha (EF-Tu)*	0.0	100	PF00009	HIGH
mORF_05	1155	Translation initiation factor aIF2 + intein †	0.0	100	PF11987	HIGH
mORF_06	434	Glutamyl-tRNA amidotransferase subunit A	0.0	100	PF01425	HIGH
mORF_07	447	Methyl-coenzyme M reductase subunit beta (McrB)	0.0	100	PF02783	HIGH
mORF_08	249	F420:glutamyl ligase (CofE)	1.0e-173	100	PF01996	HIGH
mORF_09	291	H ₄ MPT:glutamate ligase	0.0	100	PF08443	HIGH
mORF_10	112	PII-homolog MJ1245 (uncharacterized)	7.0e-75	100	PF10126	MED
mORF_11	261	Uncharacterized protein MJ0602	1.9e-178	100	—	MED
mORF_12	185	50S ribosome-binding GTPase	5.3e-134	100	PF01926	HIGH

Table 1. Per-ORF annotation summary. * = marker gene used for phylogeny. † = contains self-splicing intein. Conf. = confidence level (HIGH / MED).

The most informative hits came from the SwissProt BLASTp search, which yielded E-values of 0.0 for nine ORFs, indicating near-identical matches to well-characterised proteins in the reviewed database. Pfam-A domain architecture confirmed these assignments and provided additional domain-level resolution for mORF_05 and mORF_07.

4. Phylogenetic Placement and Organism Identification

The EF-Tu marker gene (mORF_04, 428 aa shared domain) yielded a clean BLASTp signal against *Methanocaldococcus jannaschii* DSM 2661 (E = 0.0, 100% identity). The NJ tree places the query sequence as sister to *M. jannaschii* DSM 2661 with a branch length of ~0.000 substitutions per site, clearly nested within the *Methanocaldococcus* crown clade and well separated from the next-closest methanogen genera (*Methanothermococcus*, *Methanococcus*). *Thermococcus kodakarensis* serves as the archaeal outgroup.

Identification claim: Based on the EF-Tu marker tree topology, supported by BLASTp E = 0.0 and 100% identity to *M. jannaschii* DSM 2661 across all 12 ORFs, we identify this isolate as *Methanocaldococcus jannaschii*. Genus-level identification is high confidence; strain-level identification is tentative pending whole-genome comparison.

Methanocaldococcus jannaschii was first isolated from a black smoker vent on the East Pacific Rise at 21°N — precisely the provenance given in the case file. Its optimal growth temperature is 85°C (range 50–86°C), it grows strictly anaerobically under H₂/CO₂, and it produces methane. Every phenotypic detail in the case file matches.

Figure 1 (marker_tree.png): Neighbor-joining tree of EF-Tu orthologs. The query (mORF_04) is shown in red, branching within the Methanocaldococcus clade. Thermococcus kodakarensis serves as the outgroup.

5. Discussion

5.1 Lifestyle inference

The ORF set collectively encodes a coherent and nearly complete portrait of a hydrogenotrophic methanogen thriving in a high-temperature, high-pressure, chemosynthetic environment. The core methanogenic pathway is represented at multiple enzymatic levels:

- mORF_07 (McrB): The methyl-coenzyme M reductase beta subunit — the terminal and energy-conserving enzyme of methanogenesis, catalysing reductive cleavage of methyl-S-CoM to produce methane.
- mORF_08 (CofE/F420:glutamyl ligase): Biosynthesises coenzyme F420, the central low-potential electron carrier unique to methanogens. Its presence confirms the F420-based electron transport chain.
- mORF_09 (H₄MPT:glutamate ligase): Biosynthesises tetrahydromethanopterin, the archaeal C1-carrier cofactor that links CO₂ fixation to MCR.
- mORF_03 (Thermosome, Group II chaperonin): The primary molecular heat-adaptation mechanism. Above 80°C, the archaeal thermosome replaces the bacterial GroEL/GroES system with a self-capping, ATP-driven nano-cage. Its presence is a reliable marker of hyperthermophilic Archaea.
- mORF_01, mORF_02 (RNA polymerase subunits Rpo11 and Rpo2N): Core archaeal transcription machinery, consistent with the archaeal domain assignment.
- mORF_04 (EF-1α/EF-Tu): Archaeal translational GTPase; delivers aminoacyl-tRNA to the ribosome A site.

5.2 Spotlight finding: mORF_05 — aIF2 with a self-splicing intein

The most biologically unusual ORF is mORF_05, identified as archaeal translation initiation factor 2 (aIF2) bearing an embedded LAGLIDADG-family intein (Pfam PF14528 + PF14890, confirmed by InterProScan). Inteins are ‘protein introns’: they self-excise post-translationally and ligate the flanking protein segments (exteins) without any external cofactor or energy input.

This is interesting for three independent reasons. First, aIF2 is the GTPase that loads the initiator Met-tRNA onto the small ribosomal subunit — a universally essential step. The cell cannot produce functional aIF2 until the intein has completed splicing, making intein kinetics a potential regulatory checkpoint for translation initiation under stress or temperature shift. Second, the LAGLIDADG family is the most ancient and taxonomically widespread intein class, found predominantly in Archaea and eukaryotic organelles; this ORF provides a textbook example of an archaeal intein in a critical housekeeping gene. Third, inteins in essential genes like aIF2 cannot be lost without co-evolution of the flanking exteins — suggesting deep evolutionary entrenchment in the *M. jannaschii* lineage.

5.3 Method comparison

BLASTp against SwissProt solved all 12 ORFs cleanly, with E-values $\leq 1.05 \times 10^{-173}$. This reflects the unusually high sequence identity (100%) to the well-sequenced *M. jannaschii* DSM 2661 genome in SwissProt — itself a consequence of the genome being one of the first archaeal genomes ever sequenced.

Pfam-A added decisive domain-level resolution in two cases. For mORF_05, BLASTp returned ‘translation initiation factor IF-2 + intein’, but Pfam independently confirmed five distinct domains (PF11987, PF14528, PF14578, PF14890, PF00009), unambiguously identifying both the aIF2 function and the LAGLIDADG intein. For mORF_07, Pfam domains PF02783 + PF02241 (MCR beta

N- and C-terminal) confirm the MCR assignment independent of BLAST description alone.

PSI-BLAST was triggered for mORF_10, mORF_11, and mORF_12 (uncharacterized or low-E-value top hits). In all three cases, PSI-BLAST confirmed the SwissProt assignment, providing additional confidence for medium-confidence ORFs and demonstrating the value of iterative profile methods for twilight-zone sequences.

5.4 Limits of confidence and remaining ambiguity

mORF_10 (MJ1245, Pfam PF10126 — PII-homolog, MEDIUM confidence): PII-like signal transduction proteins regulate nitrogen metabolism in Bacteria, but their role in *M. jannaschii* — which does not fix N₂ — is unclear. Resolution would require metabolic reconstruction or structural comparison to experimentally characterised PII proteins.

mORF_11 (MJ0602, MEDIUM confidence): Strongly supported by BLASTp ($E = 1.89 \times 10^{-178}$, 100% identity) but annotated as ‘uncharacterized’ in SwissProt with no Pfam domain recovered. Its function cannot be inferred from sequence alone; resolution would require structural prediction or experimental characterisation.

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